The AI Incident Response Protocol

Six Stages, and the Evidence a Reconstruction Requires

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Two clauses that accompany this protocol everywhere

This specification states no jurisdiction's notification timeline and no notifiability threshold. Both vary by jurisdiction and by authority, both change, and both are the institution's to verify against the primary sources in force where it operates. Section 5.4 specifies the record the institution writes about that determination. It does not specify the determination.

The evidence level of this specification is E1 on the scale at 3.5 of the pattern language [2]. A worked reconstruction over decision-time records from a production agent platform operated by the author is the artifact that would move it to E2. Its shape and its join are specified at Appendix D. Section 11.1 records the state of that publication and states what the level does and does not mean.

Both clauses are normative and MUST accompany any presentation of this protocol.

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Abstract

An institution asked to explain an AI failure discovers, at that moment and not before, what it wrote down. The discovery is unrecoverable. Evidence is a property of the moment a decision was taken. An institution that did not capture it then is left assembling an account from what it can still find. It reconstructs beliefs, not behaviour.

This specification defines the **AI Incident Response Protocol (AIRP)™**, an AI incident response and reconstruction protocol, in six stages: **signal**, **classify**, **contain**, **escalate**, **reconstruct** and **close**. It is entry REG-05 of the Defensible AI Framework Registry [3], and that entry governs its relationships.

Its central requirement is a design constraint on the platform. It is not a procedure for the response team. **An incident is explainable only if the evidence needed to reconstruct it existed at the moment of the decision, bound to the policy version then in force.** That requirement is already normative in four published records, cited at 2.2 and not restated: the gate passage record of the Five-Gate Deployment Model [4], the reconstruction clause of the Sharia AI Compliance Framework [7], Routing Evidence and the partial-availability rule of the pattern language [2], and the contract versions and separately recorded boundary decisions of PEVG [5]. A protocol restating those would be a second place they could drift.

What this specification owns is the consuming side, which nothing in the corpus yet states: what a reconstruction report MUST contain and how it is joined; what the signal register records, including signals closed as non-incidents, because a register of confirmed incidents alone is a numerator with no denominator; how a partial reconstruction is reported outside the engineering family, to a board or an authority that will not read an artifact inventory; how notifiability is classified; and how the conformance test derived at closure is produced. It also ships the artifact its registry entry records as missing: **Appendix C specifies an incident taxonomy**, machine-readable and aligned to the OECD AI Incidents and Hazards Monitor [8] and the AI Incident Database [10].

No institution unconnected to the author has been observed operating the protocol, no reconstruction produced under it has been examined by an external authority, and the export at Appendix D is not published. Section 11 states each of those and what would falsify the protocol. It is a specification, not a certification scheme, and no conformity assessment body operates against it.

Keywords: AI governance; incident response; incident reconstruction; evidence architecture; AI incident taxonomy; model risk management; notifiability; regulated industries; accountability.

Notation

This specification uses **MUST**, **MUST NOT**, **SHOULD**, **SHOULD NOT** and **MAY** as the normative verbal forms.

- **MUST** indicates a requirement. An implementation that does not meet it is not conformant with this specification.
- **SHOULD** indicates a recommendation. Departure requires a recorded rationale.
- **MAY** indicates a permission.

The MESA Framework specification [1] and A Pattern Language for Production LLM Platforms [2] use the verbal forms of ISO/IEC Directives Part 2, in which **shall** carries the meaning assigned to MUST here. The correspondence is exact.

Defined terms

Signal. Any input asserting that an AI system has behaved outside its approved conditions. A signal is admitted before it is assessed, and admission is not a finding. An admitted signal that assessment confirms is an **incident**. One it does not confirm is a **non-incident**. A non-incident is a record, not the absence of one. For external comparison this specification adopts the OECD definition of an AI incident [9]. 5.5 states where the two vocabularies meet.

Reconstruction. An account of what an AI system did, and of the decisions that produced it, built from artifacts written at the time of those decisions. An account built afterwards is not a reconstruction and MUST NOT be presented as one.

Decision-time evidence. An artifact written by the control that took a decision, at the moment it took it, carrying the policy or contract version then in force and the event identity of 5.2 of [2].

Notifiable. A classification recording that the institution has determined an incident engages a duty to inform an authority. **The duty, its threshold and its timing are the jurisdiction's, and this specification states none of them.**

Institution. The accountable legal entity operating the AI systems. **Regulated institution** means one whose ability to operate is conditioned on its ability to reconstruct and defend a decision to an external authority.

Sections 2 through 9 are normative. Sections 1, 10, 11 and 12 are informative, except where they state a requirement using **MUST**. Appendix C is normative.

---

1. Introduction

1.1 The problem

Incident response is a mature discipline. Most institutions that deploy AI already have one. The runbooks exist, the pagers work, the severity scale is agreed. Very little of that machinery fails when an AI system fails.

What fails is the answer to the question that follows. A conventional process is built to restore service. It succeeds by finding the change that broke the system and reversing it. A supervisor, a board or a court asks something else: what did the system decide, on what basis, under whose authority, and under which rules in force at the time. **Restoring service and explaining a decision are different capabilities. Only the second degrades silently.** An institution can rehearse the first every quarter and never discover it cannot perform the second.

The degradation is silent because the missing thing is not a procedure. It is an artifact nobody wrote, and the incident record will read as though the matter was handled. Nothing in the process reports a fault.

1.2 What a protocol is for

A protocol is an evidence consumer before it is a crisis process. Reconstruction is the only governance function that fails visibly and immediately when the evidence layer is absent. Everything else decays quietly. The registry records it as the reason the other frameworks' evidence requirements are a test rather than an aspiration [3].

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A protocol therefore fixes the order in which an institution acts under pressure, and fixes what each stage leaves behind. The account is then assembled from records. Recollection is not evidence. **The second is the harder one and is what this specification is mostly about.**

1.3 Contribution

1. **Six stages in a normative sequence**, each naming what it consumes, what it decides and what it records. Section 3.
2. **The signal register**, holding every admitted signal including non-incidents, which makes a detection rate computable. Section 4.
3. **The reconstruction report**, a required artifact with stated contents, a stated join, and a stated rule for reporting partiality outside the engineering family. Section 6.
4. **The derived conformance test**, produced at closure rather than hoped for in a postmortem. Section 7.
5. **An incident taxonomy**, machine-readable and aligned to the two public AI incident repositories. Appendix C.

1.4 Scope and non-goals

The protocol governs an institution's response to the failure of an AI system it operates. It begins at the admission of a signal. It ends at closure and the changes closure produces. It is calibrated to regulated institutions and assumes a conventional incident response capability, which it extends rather than replaces.

- **Not a replacement for enterprise incident response.** Service restoration, paging and communications remain the institution's existing discipline.
- **Not a severity scale.** 5.2 states the properties an institution's scale MUST have and supplies none, because severity carries authority and authority is assigned by CADRE [3].
- **Not a statement of any notification duty.** Per the front matter and 5.4.
- **Not a specification of the frameworks whose evidence it consumes.** Those are named at Section 2 and catalogued at [3].
- **Not a certification scheme**, and **not an empirical claim.** No conformity assessment body operates against this specification, and Section 11 states what has not been tested.

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2. The Reconstruction Precondition (Normative)

2.1 The requirement

An incident is explainable only if the evidence needed to reconstruct it existed at the moment of the decision, bound to the policy version then in force.

This constrains the platform, not the response team. No stage of this protocol can create decision-time evidence, because the time at which it could have been created has passed. **A response team can only be as good as the platform was diligent.**

2.2 What this specification does not restate

The requirement is already normative in four published records. **This specification cites them and MUST NOT be read as restating them**, because a requirement written down twice is a requirement that can be written down twice differently, which is the failure the registry's closure rule exists to prevent [3].

Producer	The clause that binds	What it fixes for reconstruction
Five-Gate 2.5 [4]	The gate passage record, including the policy version in force at the time of the decision	Who accepted the system, on what evidence, under which rules
SACF 7.3 [7]	The reconstruction MUST be evidence produced at the time of the decisions in question	That an after-the-fact account does not satisfy an authority at the floor
Pattern language IP-4 and 5.2.7 [2]	Routing Evidence carrying the policy version that decided the route; a reconstruction missing an artifact is reported as partial and names it	Why a request went where it went, and how an incomplete answer is disclosed

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Producer	The clause that binds	What it fixes for reconstruction
PEVG 3.4 and 8.3 [5]	Each contract carries a version and the evidence records which were in force; the verification and disclosure decisions are recorded separately	What an agent workflow was permitted to believe, and what it was permitted to say

An institution operating this protocol MUST satisfy those clauses in the specifications that state them, and a conformance claim under Section 9 is available only to an institution that does.

2.3 What follows for the consumer

Three consequences follow. Each is normative here, because each concerns the reading of evidence rather than its production.

1. **The join is the deliverable.** A reconstruction is not a collection of artifacts. It is those artifacts joined on the event identity of 5.2 of [2] into one account of one event. **An institution holding every required artifact and unable to join them has an archive.** It does not have a reconstruction capability.
2. **A gap is named, never smoothed.** Where an artifact is unavailable, 5.2.7 of [2] governs. Section 6.3 specifies how that partiality travels outside the engineering family, which 5.2.7 does not address and does not claim to.
3. **The protocol inherits the limits of its suppliers.** AIRP cannot compensate for an upstream framework that produced no evidence. An institution operating it over frameworks that write no records has an escalation procedure, and SHOULD say so rather than call what it has reconstruction.

---

3. The Six Stages (Normative)

3.1 The sequence

An institution MUST execute the stages in the order signal, classify, contain, escalate, reconstruct, close, and MUST NOT close an incident whose reconstruct stage has produced neither the artifact at Section 6 nor a recorded statement that it could not.

The sequence is normative for one reason and it is not tidiness. Classification determines authority, authority determines who may contain, and containment taken before authority is assigned is containment nobody is accountable for. **An institution that reorders the first three stages has decided to discover afterwards who was allowed to do what it already did.**

Two concurrencies are specified rather than tolerated. **Contain and escalate MAY overlap**, because containment that waits for an escalation extends the exposure it exists to end. **Reconstruct MAY begin during containment** and MUST NOT delay it.

Stage	Consumes	Decides	Records
Signal	Detection triggers armed at gate five [4]; drift and bias alarms; override rates; complaint patterns; gate breaches; vendor notifications; authority inquiries; internal and external reports	Admission only	Signal register entry, Section 4
Classify	The register entry; the severity scale and decision rights of CADRE [3]; the failure taxonomy at Section 6 of [1]; the board's materiality determination where [7] applies	Four classifications, Section 5	Classification record
Contain	The classification and the authority it carries	Rollback, route-around, agent authority suspension, review-tier elevation	Containment record

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Stage	Consumes	Decides	Records
Escalate	The escalation paths and decision rights of CADRE [3]	Nothing of its own	Escalation record per path, including paths not taken
Reconstruct	The decision-time evidence of every supplying framework; seven supply edges point at this entry [3]	Complete or partial, and what is missing	Reconstruction report, Section 6
Close	The reconstruction report and the containment record	That the incident is closed, and by whom	Closure record, Section 7

3.2 Signal, and classify

Admission MUST NOT depend on a preliminary judgement that the signal is likely to be confirmed, because the party best placed to form that judgement is frequently the party whose work the signal concerns. A conventional detection step filters. This one admits, and then records the outcome including the outcome that nothing happened.

A revised classification MUST be recorded as a revision with both values retained, because the classification in force when containment was chosen is a fact about the incident and is not superseded by a later view.

3.3 Contain

Where containment withdraws a system from production it is a rollback under 4.1 of [4] and MUST be recorded as the gate decision that specification requires. This protocol adds no second rollback rule and defines no second record. **The evidence of the reversal MUST be preserved**, per 4.1 of [4], because the period an authority asks about is the period the containment ended.

Where an agent's authority is suspended, the suspension MUST be effected against the faculty authority the agent holds under PARA [6] and the capability contract it operates under [5], and MUST NOT be effected only by removing the agent's entry point. An agent unreachable at its interface and still holding its authority has been hidden rather than contained.

The containment record names the action, the authority under which it was taken, the person who took it, the time, and the state of the system before and after.

3.4 Escalate

Escalation routes; it does not adjudicate. The record MUST cover each path taken **and each path considered and not taken, with the reason.** A path not taken is the record an authority is most likely to ask for. Where [7] applies and the incident is Sharia-material, escalation to the Sharia Supervisory Board is concurrent with civil escalation under 7.1 of [7], and this protocol carries that requirement without modifying it.

3.5 Reconstruct and close

What the reconstruct stage adds to the requirement at Section 2 is that the reconstruction is **produced as an artifact in its own right**. A postmortem is not that artifact. An institution that writes only a postmortem has produced a narrative it authored. A reconstruction report is a joined account of records it did not.

The closure record carries, at minimum, the postmortem; the revalidation trigger raised into the MESA MRM Framework [3]; where the reconstruction calls the system's fitness into question, the loop-back reopening gate two under 4.2 of [4]; and the derived conformance test at 7.3. **Closure is a decision, not a state an incident reaches.** An incident whose containment has ended and whose closure record is unwritten is open.

3.6 What the stages do not do

The stages produce no primary evidence about the AI system. **Every artifact this protocol reads was written by a control operating under another framework.** An institution operating six stages over frameworks producing no decision-time evidence has a well-documented response to an event it cannot explain. 11.2 states what that costs.

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3.7 Figure 1

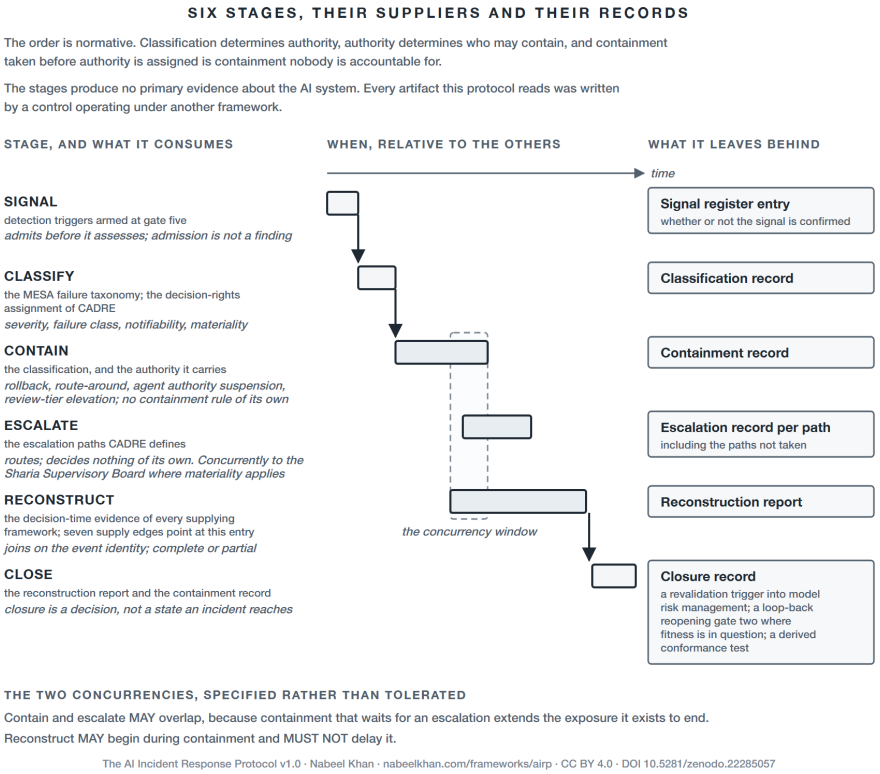


Figure 1. The six stages, their suppliers and their records. Signal admits from the detection triggers armed at gate five and writes a register entry whether or not the signal is confirmed. Classify draws its failure class from the MESA failure taxonomy and its severity authority from the decision-rights assignment of CADRE. Contain exercises a Five-Gate rollback, a route-around, an authority suspension or a review-tier elevation, and adds no containment rule of its own. Escalate routes along paths CADRE defines, and concurrently to the Sharia Supervisory Board where materiality applies. Reconstruct joins decision-time evidence on the event identity and produces the reconstruction report. Close raises a revalidation trigger into model risk management, a loop-back reopening gate two where fitness is in question, and a derived conformance test. Contain and escalate overlap; reconstruct may begin during containment and never delays it. **DOI https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.33420193**

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4. The Signal Register (Normative)

4.1 Every admitted signal, including those that came to nothing

An institution MUST maintain a signal register holding one record per admitted signal, including every signal closed as a non-incident. This is the requirement institutions most often decline, and the reason they decline it is the reason it is here. A register of confirmed incidents is shorter, cleaner and easier to present. It is also a numerator with no denominator.

4.2 What an entry MUST carry

Field	What it fixes
Signal identifier	A stable key, never reused
Event identity or identities	The join key of 5.2 of [2], where the signal concerns identifiable events
Detection channel	Which enumerated channel raised it, per Appendix C
Raised at, admitted at	Both times, because the interval is a property of the institution rather than of the incident
Raiser	The person, system or external party that raised it

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Field	What it fixes
Assessment outcome	Incident, hazard or non-incident, per Appendix C
Classification reference	Where the outcome is an incident, the classification record of Section 5
Closure reason	Where the outcome is a non-incident, why

An entry MUST NOT be deleted, and a signal reassessed later is recorded as a revision with both outcomes retained.

4.3 Why the non-incidents are the point

A detection rate is confirmed signals over admitted signals. **An institution that records only confirmed signals cannot compute one, and therefore cannot tell a tightened threshold from a degraded one.** Both produce fewer confirmed incidents. Only one of them is an improvement.

The same register answers the question an authority asks after an incident raised twice and confirmed once: whether the first signal was assessed and closed on a stated basis, or never admitted at all. Those are different failures with different remedies. The register is where the difference survives.

4.4 What the register is not

It is not a monitoring system and not a ticket queue. **An entry is written on admission, by the protocol.** The retention period is the institution's evidence retention period. It is not the operational one. A signal history living only in a ticketing system expires ahead of the obligations it serves.

---

5. Classification (Normative)

5.1 Four classifications

The classify stage MUST assign all four of the following, and MUST record any later change as a revision rather than as a correction: severity per 5.2, failure class per 5.3, notifiability per 5.4, and Sharia materiality where [7] applies, per 5.5.

5.2 Severity, which this specification does not supply

An institution MUST hold a severity scale fixed in advance in the decision-rights assignment of CADRE [3], and that scale MUST have three properties.

- **Severity carries authority.** Each level states what the incident lead may do without further approval. A scale assigning only a response time has assigned nothing that matters at the moment it is used.
- **Escalation of severity is unilateral; de-escalation is not.** The bias under pressure runs toward under-classification, and a scale equally easy to move in both directions moves in one.
- **The level in force at each decision is recorded**, per 5.1.

This specification supplies no scale, because a scale supplied here would be adopted by institutions it does not fit. The five-tier scale of the source treatment is recorded at Appendix B as prior treatment.

5.3 Failure class, which the MESA Framework supplies

The failure class MUST be assigned from the taxonomy at Section 6 of [1], whose classes F1 through F7 name the altitude at which the governance chain broke and thereby determine which layer owns the remedy. This protocol adds nothing to that taxonomy and MUST NOT be read as extending it.

MESA records that F6 is the class most often misclassified as F3 [1, Section 6]. The consequence for a consumer is that **where the reconstruction is partial, the institution MUST consider F6 before concluding F3.**

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5.4 Notifiability, and the record it writes

The classify stage MUST assign one of three values, notifiable, not notifiable or undetermined, naming the authority the value refers to, and MUST write a notifiability decision record carrying the authority and the instrument the institution believes engages the duty; the value assigned and the person who assigned it; the facts relied on and the time at which they were known; the date of the primary-source verification the institution performed; where the value is notifiable, the dated notification record; and where the value is not notifiable, **the dated rationale**, which is a required artifact rather than an optional one.

Undetermined is a permitted value and MUST carry a review date. An institution that has not determined notifiability has a state. Undetermined is that state. Recording it as not notifiable to avoid an empty field misrepresents it.

No timeline, threshold or trigger appears in this specification. Jurisdictions impose serious-incident reporting duties on providers of AI systems, and Article 73 of the European Union's Artificial Intelligence Act [12] is one instance among several; its conditions, addressee and timing are the primary source's to state. The registry records these as ageing assertions the institution re-verifies [3].

5.5 Sharia materiality, and external comparability

Where the institution has constituted a Sharia Supervisory Board and [7] applies, **materiality is determined by the board and MUST NOT be inferred by the response function**, under 3.3 of [7]. Where materiality is unclear at the moment of an incident, 7.2 of [7] governs and the institution escalates.

Separately, **the institution MUST assign the external classification of Appendix C** so that the incident can be positioned against the populations held by the OECD AI Incidents and Hazards Monitor [8] and the AI Incident Database [10]. Assigning it is an internal act with no external effect: neither repository is notified, no submission is implied, and the classification MUST NOT be represented as a filing.

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6. The Reconstruction Report (Normative)

6.1 What the report MUST contain

A reconstruction report MUST be produced for every incident classified as notifiable, and SHOULD be produced for every confirmed incident. It MUST carry all of the following.

#	Element	What it fixes
1	The event identity or identities, and the window	What is being reconstructed, bounded in time
2	The AI system and the version that was operating	The unit, per the definition at [4]
3	The decision or decisions in question, as outcomes	What the system did, before any account of why
4	The artifact inventory	Every decision-time artifact sought, whether found, and where retrieved from
5	The policy, contract and configuration versions in force	Per 2.5 of [4], 3.4 of [5] and IP-4 of [2]
6	The authority chain	Which named person accepted the system at which gate, under which decision right
7	The reconstructed account	The join, as a sequence, each step attributed to the artifact that evidences it
8	Completeness statement	Complete or partial, and where partial every missing artifact named, per 6.3
9	The failure class	Per 5.3, with the reasoning distinguishing F6 from F3 where relevant

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#	Element	What it fixes
10	Author, date, and the retrieval date of each artifact class	So that the report can itself be reconstructed

Where the system incorporates a third-party model or service, the vendor evidence of the AI Vendor Risk Framework [14] is part of element 4 and its version part of element 5.

Element 7 MUST attribute each step to an artifact. A step no artifact evidences is an inference. An unmarked inference inside a reconstruction is the defect the report exists to prevent. **An inference MAY appear, and MUST be marked as one.**

6.2 The join

The reconstruction MUST be built by joining artifacts on the event identity of 5.2 of [2], and MUST NOT be built by correlating timestamps across systems. Timestamp correlation produces an account that is usually right and cannot be shown to be right. That is the property that fails under examination. Where an artifact carries no event identity, the institution MUST record it as unjoined, MUST state the basis on which it was associated with the event, and MUST treat the reconstruction as partial under 6.3.

Causal parentage, retries and provider boundaries are governed by 5.2.3, 5.2.4 and 5.2.5 of [2] and are not restated. One consumer-side consequence follows: a fan-out that a reconstruction reads as a sequence produces a causal claim the evidence does not support, and an institution unable to distinguish the two SHOULD say so in element 8 rather than choose one.

6.3 Partial reconstruction, and how it travels

Where an artifact is unavailable, the reconstruction MUST be reported as partial and MUST name the missing artifact, per 5.2.7 of [2]. That rule is the producer's. What this section adds is what happens when the report leaves the engineering family, which 5.2.7 does not address.

A board, a supervisor or a court will not read an artifact inventory. A missing filename is not a finding. A partiality expressed that way is lost in the summary. **A partial reconstruction reported outside the engineering family MUST therefore carry all three of the following, in the body of what is presented and not in an annex to it.**

1. **The question the reconstruction cannot answer**, stated in the reader's terms. Not ”the routing evidence for the interval is absent” but ”the reconstruction cannot establish which model produced the decision”.
2. **The consequence for reliance**, stated as a limit on what may be concluded.
3. **The remedy and its owner**, because a named gap with no owner recurs, and the same gap appearing in a second reconstruction is the finding an authority treats most seriously.

A partial reconstruction MUST NOT be presented as complete. A summary omitting the partiality misrepresents the record. It does not simplify it. **An acknowledged gap is a smaller problem than an unacknowledged one**, because the second invites reliance the evidence does not support.

6.4 Who reads it

The report is written for a reader who was not present. That reader is the test. **It MUST be intelligible to a competent reader outside the team that operated the system**, and an institution SHOULD have it read by such a person before relying on it externally.

6.5 Figure 2

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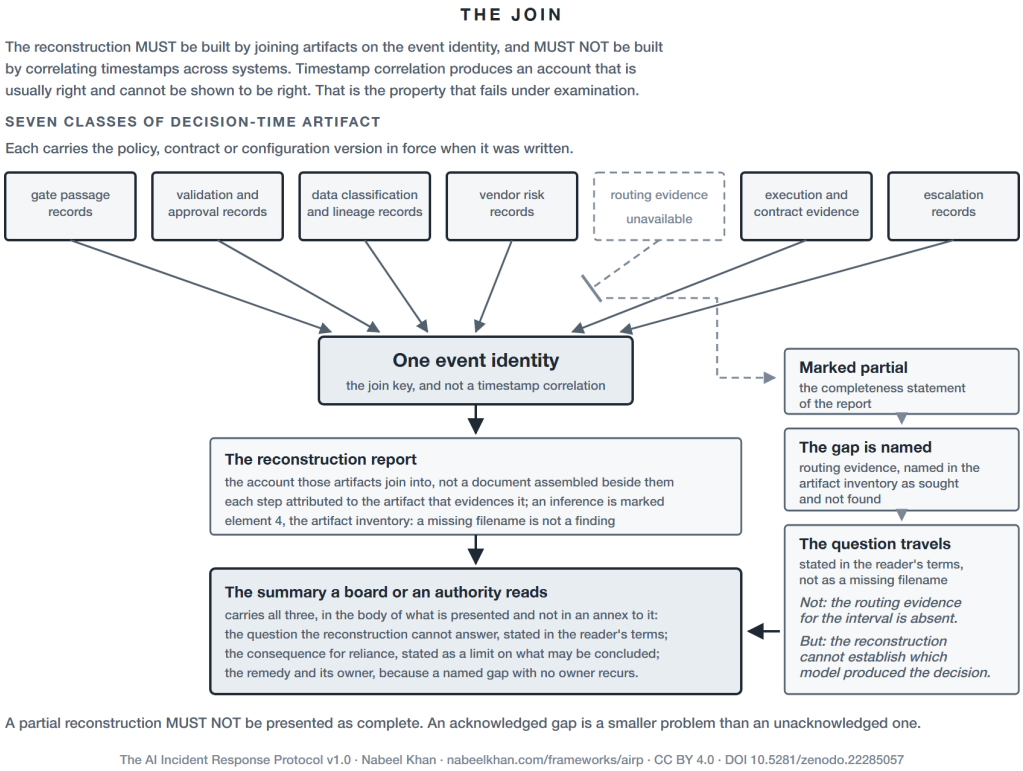


Figure 2. The join. Seven classes of decision-time artifact converge on one event identity: gate passage records, validation and approval records, data classification and lineage records, vendor risk records, routing evidence, execution and contract evidence, and escalation records. Each carries the policy, contract or configuration version in force when it was written, and the reconstruction report is the account those artifacts join into rather than a document assembled beside them. One artifact class is shown absent, and the figure carries what the absence does: the report is marked partial, the missing artifact is named, and the question the reconstruction cannot answer travels into the summary a board or an authority reads rather than remaining in the artifact inventory. **DOI https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.33420196**

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7. Closure (Normative)

7.1 The closure record

An incident MUST NOT be closed without a closure record carrying the postmortem, the revalidation trigger, the loop-back decision where one applies, and the derived conformance test. The record names the person who closed the incident, who MUST be the incident lead or the named deputy.

7.2 What closure raises upstream

A revalidation trigger MUST be raised into the MESA MRM Framework [3] for every confirmed incident concerning a system under model risk management, whether or not the incident is attributed to the model.

Where the reconstruction calls the system's fitness into question, gate two MUST be reopened under 4.2 of [4]. This protocol adds no criterion of its own for when that applies: which incidents trigger loop-back is defined in advance in the revalidation trigger register, per 3.6 and 4.2 of [4], and MUST NOT be decided after the incident by the people whose work would be reopened.

7.3 The derived conformance test

Closure MUST produce one test that would have detected the failure before it reached production, or a recorded statement that no such test can be constructed and why.

This converts an incident into something the institution keeps. It is specified, not left to the postmortem. An action item is owned by whoever accepted it. A conformance test is owned by the pipeline. A derived test MUST carry four properties.

1. **Executable.** A test a person performs by reading is a review, and it will be skipped under schedule pressure. Where a failure genuinely cannot be detected automatically, the institution records that under the exception in this clause rather than describing a manual review as a test.
2. **Placed.** The test names the gate or pipeline stage at which it runs. A test with no placement runs nowhere.
3. **Shown to fail. The test MUST be shown to fail when run against the conditions the reconstruction established**, which is the only evidence that it tests the failure that occurred rather than the institution's account of it. A test that has never failed has not been shown to test anything.
4. **Attributed.** The test carries the incident identifier. A later change removing it can then be traced to the incident it came from.

Where no test can be constructed, the recorded statement MUST name the class of failure the institution has accepted it cannot detect in advance, and that statement is an input to the next assessment under [1] rather than a closure of the matter.

7.4 Closure is not remediation

Closure records that the incident is understood and that the changes it produced are owned. **It does not assert that those changes are complete**, and an institution MUST NOT represent a closed incident as a remediated one. Remediation is tracked to its own completion on the cadence of CADRE [3].

---

8. Accountability (Normative)

The accountable role for this protocol MUST be a single named person, the incident lead in the governance office. A committee, a function, a team or a board MUST NOT be recorded as the accountable role. This inherits 3.3 of [3] and 2.3 of [4] and is not argued again.

A named deputy MUST be part of the appointment rather than an addition to it. The role is exercised at the moment an incident occurs, which is not a moment at which an institution can appoint anyone. 2.3 of [4] gives the reason. Here the bypass has a name. Whoever is nearest the alert answers it, and the authority stays in the org chart.

A governance committee, a board or an executive **MAY** hold the decision to accept the residual exposure a closure records, **MAY** approve a remediation plan, and **MAY** direct the response. **None of those is the accountable role.**

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The source treatment assigns the recovery decision to a committee, and Appendix B records that as prior treatment this specification does not carry.

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9. Conformance (Normative)

Conformance is **self-declared**. No conformity assessment body operates against this specification, and no third party is accredited to assess a claim made under it.

A claim requires all of the following for a stated period.

1. A signal register holding one entry per admitted signal including non-incidents, per Section 4.
2. A classification record per confirmed incident carrying all four classifications, per Section 5.
3. A notifiability decision record per confirmed incident, including a dated rationale where the value is not notifiable, per 5.4.
4. A reconstruction report for every incident classified as notifiable, meeting Section 6, with every partial reconstruction reported per 6.3.
5. A closure record per closed incident carrying the revalidation trigger, the loop-back decision where applicable, and the derived conformance test or the recorded statement that none could be constructed, per Section 7.
6. A named incident lead and a named deputy, appointed in advance, per Section 8.
7. The upstream clauses at 2.2 satisfied in the specifications that state them.

A published claim MUST carry the two clauses in the front matter, the period claimed for, the date of the evidence, and the version claimed against.

What a claim does not mean. It does not mean the institution's incidents were handled well; it means the records specified here exist. It does not mean the institution can reconstruct any given incident, because reconstruction depends on evidence this protocol does not produce, per 2.3. It does not mean any notification duty has been satisfied. It does not mean the institution has been assessed, because nobody assessed it. It does not mean a certification exists, because none does.

A claim lapses at the end of the period it was made for and MUST NOT be represented as continuing. An institution that has not produced the artifacts above in a later period has no claim for that period. A weakened claim is not available.

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10. Related Work

Cybersecurity incident response. NIST SP 800-61 Revision 3 [11] states incident response recommendations as a Cybersecurity Framework 2.0 community profile and is the closest general instrument. The relationship runs one way. **An institution operating that guidance already holds the response machinery this protocol assumes.** What this protocol adds is the reconstruction obligation at Section 6 and the precondition at Section 2. A cybersecurity incident ordinarily requires neither. Restoring a compromised service does not require an account of which model decided what, under which policy version, on whose authority. An AI incident also frequently presents as a system operating correctly and deciding wrongly, which system-level monitoring does not detect.

The public incident repositories. The OECD AI Incidents and Hazards Monitor [8] tracks AI incidents and hazards from international news reporting and rests on the definitions published as OECD Artificial Intelligence Papers No. 16 [9], which separate an AI incident, where harm occurred, from an AI hazard, where harm could plausibly follow. The AI Incident Database [10], operated by the Responsible AI Collaborative, catalogues incidents and carries several independently maintained taxonomies over them. **Both are external populations rather than reporting channels, and neither is an authority.** Appendix C specifies the alignment.

Regulatory incident reporting. Jurisdictions impose serious-incident reporting duties on providers of AI systems, and Article 73 of the European Union's Artificial Intelligence Act [12] is one instance. **This specification states no such duty and no timeline**, and an institution MUST perform its own crosswalk against the instruments in force where it operates.

The governance family. The protocol is entry REG-05 of the Defensible AI Framework Registry [3], the canonical source for its relationships to every framework named here. **Where this specification and the registry**

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describe the same relationship, the registry governs, because two documents asserting one relationship will otherwise drift.

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11. Limitations, What Has Not Been Tested, and Falsification

11.1 The evidence level is E1 until the export at Appendix D is published

Stated first because it is the most important thing about this document.

On the scale at 3.5 of [2], **this specification is at E1**, and the reason is narrower than a reader might assume. It is not that nothing supports the combination specified here. **The mechanism at Appendix D exists.** A production agent platform operated by the author writes both of the runtime records that appendix names, and correlates them on a propagated event identity. What is outstanding is the **redacted export**, which is a publication step rather than a capability.

E2 is not claimed, and MUST NOT be inferred from this section. The definition at 3.5 of [2] is a documented implementation. Documented means published. It also means inspectable by someone other than its author. An author's statement that his own system holds the records is not that document. **The level moves when the export at Appendix D is published, and not before.**

One convergence is worth recording and worth not overstating. **6.2 requires that a reconstruction be joined on a propagated event identity rather than correlated on timestamps, and the platform described above was built to do exactly that, independently of this specification.** That the requirement was arrived at twice could mean three things: that the requirement is implementable, that it is correct, or that it is necessary. Only the first is available, and it is the weakest. It is not evidence that the requirement is correct: a single platform the same author operates is not independent, which is the point 11.2 makes about everything in this document.

11.2 Untested, and dependent on evidence it does not produce

No third party has published a result obtained under this protocol, and no reconstruction produced under it has been examined by an external authority, which is the examination that would establish whether the report at Section 6 answers the question authorities actually ask. Everything in Sections 2 through 9 is an architectural claim. It is coherent. Whether a reconstruction built this way survives contact with a regulator is the open question, and no regulator has been shown one.

Reconstruction is also possible only to the extent that the other frameworks kept their evidence. An institution can operate all six stages faithfully, produce every record at Section 9, and be unable to reconstruct a single incident, because the artifacts it needed were never written. Its conformance claim would be true. It would not mean what a reader might take it to mean, which is why Section 9 says so.

11.3 The taxonomy at Appendix C is a mapping, not a standard

The alignment to the two public repositories is this author's mapping. **Neither the OECD nor the Responsible AI Collaborative has reviewed or endorsed it**, and neither accepts submissions in the form Appendix C produces. It closes the registry's missing-artifact gap in the sense that an institution can position its record against an external population. It does not make those classifications interoperable with either repository's own annotation process, and MUST NOT be presented as doing so.

11.4 No severity scale, no templates, and an unmeasured cost

No severity scale is supplied, per 5.2. Two institutions operating AIRP will classify the same incident differently. **No reconstruction report template is published.** What a report looks like is left to each institution to construct from the field list at 6.1. Both are the highest-value additions available to a future version. Separately, a signal register holding non-incidents, a report per notifiable incident and a test per closure is a materially larger evidence burden than a conventional incident record. **What that costs has not been measured.** Neither has the scale below which it stops being proportionate to the risk.

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11.5 What would falsify the protocol

The protocol is falsified if institutions holding complete upstream decision-time records are found no better able to reconstruct an AI incident, to a standard an external authority accepts, than institutions holding conventional application and infrastructure logs.

The distinguishing claim is that decision-time evidence bound to a policy version is what reconstruction requires. Evidence that ordinary logging suffices would collapse the distinction the protocol is built on. The test is observable. Any party with access to both kinds of institution can run it. Three narrower findings would refute parts of it. If institutions maintaining a signal register that holds non-incidents detect no more incidents, and no earlier, than institutions registering confirmed incidents only, Section 4 is a register that costs attention and returns none. If reconstructions built by timestamp correlation are accepted by authorities as readily as those built on a propagated event identity, 6.2 is a distinction without a difference. And if incidents closed with a derived conformance test recur at the same rate as those closed with a postmortem action item, 7.3 is paperwork attached to a closure.

11.6 Research questions

1. Does a reconstruction built from decision-time evidence change an authority's judgement of an institution, relative to one built from conventional logs?
2. What does producing a reconstruction report cost, and at what institutional scale does it stop being proportionate?
3. Does a signal register holding non-incidents change detection behaviour, or only measure it?
4. Do incidents closed with an executable derived test recur less often than those closed with an action item?

A reader able to answer any of these from real incident evidence is invited to make contact through the ORCID record in the front matter. Question one is the one this protocol most needs answered, and its author cannot answer it.

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12. Versioning

The major number changes when a change could make a previously conformant institution non-conformant: a stage is added, removed or reordered, a required element of 6.1 is added, a requirement in Section 9 is tightened, or a value is removed from the taxonomy at Appendix C.

The minor number changes for additions and clarifications that cannot, including a new value added to a taxonomy enumeration, a corrected limitation, the addition of a report template or a severity instrument, and the population of Appendix D.

The six stage names are normative and MUST NOT be renamed. A stage retired in a future version is marked retired rather than removed. Former names carried by prior treatments are recorded at Appendix B and remain valid for citation of that earlier work.

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13. References

Every reference was verified against a live primary source, each with a deliberate failing control, because a check that cannot fail proves nothing. Verification date: 6 September 2026. Two checks reached an authoritative substitute rather than the page the citation points to, and are recorded as such: the OECD landing page for [9] refused the request, so its series number was confirmed from the Crossref DOI record and the OECD-supplied RePEc entry; and the EUR-Lex full text for [12] truncated before the enacting articles, so the heading of Article 73 was confirmed from the European Commission's own AI Act Service Desk. For [10] the arXiv record evidences acceptance to IAAI-21 as declared on the preprint, not a fetched proceedings entry.

[1] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The MESA Framework: A Four-Altitude Diagnostic Model for Institutional AI Governance. Framework Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22109836

[2] Khan, N. A. (2026). *A Pattern Language for Production LLM Platforms: Governed Routing, Agent Orchestration, and AI-Native Delivery. Pattern Language Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22109864

doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22285057

[3] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The Defensible AI Framework Registry: Canonical Names, Definitions and Relationships for the Governed Production AI Discipline. Registry Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170112

[4] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The Five-Gate Deployment Model: A Deployment Discipline for AI Systems. Deployment Model Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170122

[5] Khan, N. A. (2026). *PEVG: Planner, Executor, Verifier, Generator. Four Contracts, and the Two Boundaries a Verifier Does Not Both Hold.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170132

[6] Khan, N. A. (2026). *PARA: Perception, Action, Reasoning, Adaptation. Four Faculties, Four Authority Types, and the Registry Entry That Turns a Faculty into a Contract.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170139

[7] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The Sharia AI Compliance Framework: A Dual-Authority Governance Architecture for Islamic Finance. Framework Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170143

[8] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. *AI Incidents and Hazards Monitor.* OECD.AI. https://oecd.ai/en/incidents

[9] Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (2024). *Defining AI incidents and related terms.* OECD Artificial Intelligence Papers No. 16, May 2024. https://doi.org/10.1787/d1a8d965-en

[10] Responsible AI Collaborative. *AI Incident Database.* https://incidentdatabase.ai. Described in McGregor, S. (2021). *Preventing Repeated Real World AI Failures by Cataloging Incidents: The AI Incident Database.* IAAI-21. arXiv:2011.08512

[11] Nelson, A., Rekhi, S., Souppaya, M. and Scarfone, K. (2025). *Incident Response Recommendations and Considerations for Cybersecurity Risk Management: A CSF 2.0 Community Profile.* NIST Special Publication 800-61 Revision 3, April 2025. https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.SP.800-61r3

[12] European Union (2024). *Regulation (EU) 2024/1689 laying down harmonised rules on artificial intelligence.* Article 73, reporting of serious incidents. **Cited as an instance of a reporting duty; its conditions, addressee and timing are not stated in this specification.**

[13] Khan, N. A. (2026). *AI Governance and Compliance Frameworks for the Middle East: The Enterprise Playbook.* First Edition. iSystematic Inc. ISBN 978-1-0678960-1-0

[14] Khan, N. A. (2026). *The AI Vendor Due-Diligence Questionnaire: AVRF Instrument for Third-Party AI Systems, Models and APIs. Questionnaire Specification.* Zenodo. Concept DOI https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22170146

Appendix A. Publication Provenance

A.1 First public version of this specification. Not peer reviewed. Deposited on Zenodo, which confers a DOI, a timestamp and citability. **Zenodo does not confer standard status, and nothing in this document uses that word for itself.** The two figures are not embedded in this record: they are deposited separately, carry their own identifiers, and are cited from their captions, each of which is written to carry the argument on its own.

A.2 The protocol was named and used before this specification, principally in chapter 15 of [13] and across the author's practice. This document is its first standalone, versioned statement. It is also the first to state the reconstruction precondition at Section 2 as the central claim. Earlier it was one phase among several. **The reframing from a crisis process to an evidence consumer is recorded in the change history of registry entry REG-05** [3] and is the substantive difference between this specification and its source treatment.

A.3 No preprint identifier exists and no preprint relation is asserted in this record's metadata.

A.4 Publication order. This record publishes after the eight records deposited on 30 August 2026 and before the next version of the registry. Registry entry REG-05 remains the canonical statement of this protocol's relationships and governs where the two describe the same relationship. **That entry records this framework's specification status as `source-treatment`; the value changes to `deposited` in the next registry version, which is a change to the registry rather than to this document.**

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A.5 The author operates a consulting practice applying this protocol, which is a conflict of interest stated here. The mitigations are the lesser ones available to any single-author instrument: the stage names cannot be renamed, the falsification conditions are published, the limitations are stated rather than inferred, and the evidence level is stated as E1 rather than claimed as E2. **None of these makes the specification independent.**

A.6 The alignment at Appendix C was constructed from the public documentation of the two repositories named in it and from no private communication with either. **Neither organization has been contacted, and neither has reviewed, endorsed or is associated with this specification.**

Appendix B. Naming Crosswalk: Prior Treatment and This Specification

The source treatment at chapter 15 of [13] states the protocol in **seven phases**. This specification states it in **six stages**, following registry entry REG-05 [3], which governs. **The seven phase names remain valid for citation of the earlier work** and MUST NOT be used to name a stage of this specification.

Prior phase [13]	Stage here	Note
Phase One: Detection	**Signal**	Admits before assessing, and its register holds non-incidents, which the prior treatment does not require
Phase Two: Triage	**Classify**	Four classifications at Section 5, where the prior treatment fixes severity and routing
Phase Three: Containment	**Contain**	Containment that withdraws a system is a Five-Gate rollback, per 3.4, rather than an action of the protocol's own
Phase Four: Investigation	**Reconstruct**	The substantive change. Investigation produces a diagnosis; reconstruction produces a joined account of decision-time records, and Section 6 specifies it as an artifact
Phase Five: Remediation	*Not a stage*	Tracked to completion outside the protocol, per 7.4. Its initiation is a closure output
Phase Six: Recovery	*Not a stage*	Return to production is passage of gate four under [4]. The prior treatment assigns the decision to a committee; Section 8 does not carry that assignment, because registry 3.3 and Five-Gate 2.3 forbid a committee as the accountable role
Phase Seven: Post-Incident Review	**Close**	The postmortem is one element of the closure record. Section 7 adds the revalidation trigger, the loop-back decision and the derived conformance test as required outputs
No prior phase	**Escalate**	Present in the prior treatment as an escalation matrix operating across phases, and stated here as a stage with its own records, including paths considered and not taken

Two named constructs of the prior treatment are recorded as prior treatment and are not carried.

- **Incident Commander.** The accountable role here is the **incident lead** in the governance office, with a named deputy, per Section 8 and registry 4.5.10 [3]. The change is one of name and appointment discipline rather than of function.
- **The five-tier severity scale, P0 to P4, with response service levels.** This specification supplies no severity scale, per 5.2, and states the properties an institution's scale MUST have instead.

Appendix C. The AIRP Incident Taxonomy (Normative)

Registry entry REG-05 records the absence of an incident taxonomy aligned to the public AI incident repositories as this framework's missing artifact [3]. Without one, an institution's classifications remain internal and its record cannot be compared to any population outside itself. This appendix is that artifact.

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An institution operating this protocol MUST assign the values below to every confirmed incident and every recorded hazard, and MAY assign them to a non-incident. **The taxonomy is published as `airp-incident-taxonomy-v1.0.json`, deposited with this record**, which is the artifact a tool consumes and which governs where the two differ. This appendix describes it rather than restating it field by field.

Dimension	Source of the vocabulary	Note
`event_class`	OECD [9]	`incident`, `hazard`, `non_incident`. The first two are the OECD definitions; the third is this protocol's, for the signal register, and has no OECD counterpart
`harm_category`	OECD [9]	The four harm categories of the OECD definition, plus `none_realized`
`failure_class`	MESA Section 6 [1]	`F1` to `F7`, by reference. The definitions are MESA's and are not restated
`detection_channel`	This protocol	Nine enumerated channels, per Section 4
`containment_action`	This protocol, bound to [4], [5] and [6]	Rollback, route-around, authority suspension, review-tier elevation, none
`reconstruction_status`	Pattern language 5.2.7 [2]	`complete`, `partial`, `not_attempted`, with `missing_artifacts` required when partial
`notifiability`	This protocol	`notifiable`, `not_notifiable`, `undetermined`. **Carries no timeline and no threshold**, per 5.4
`sharia_materiality`	SACF 3.3 [7]	`material`, `not_material`, `undetermined`, `not_applicable`. Determined by the board, never inferred
`external_reference`	OECD [8], AIID [10]	Optional identifiers where the same event appears in a public repository, and the taxonomy under which it was annotated

No severity dimension is defined, per 5.2. An institution's severity value is carried as a free value paired with `severity_scale_id`, so that a record states which scale produced it.

What the alignment does not achieve. It runs **one way**, from an AIRP record to a description a reader of either repository can interpret. It does not make a record ingestible by either repository, it implies no submission, and it is endorsed by neither organization. The two also differ in a way the mapping preserves rather than resolves: the OECD monitor classifies events detected in news reporting against its own definitions [8][9], while the AI Incident Database carries several independently maintained taxonomies, including the CSET AI Harm Taxonomy, Goals Methods and Failures, and the MIT AI Risk Repository, **which are the responsibility of the parties contributing them rather than of the database** [10]. An AIRP record therefore aligns to the OECD vocabulary directly, and to the AI Incident Database by reference to an incident identifier and its annotating taxonomy.

Appendix D. Worked Reconstruction Trace

The mechanism is specified below. The redacted export is not published. The records will be drawn from a production agent platform operated by the author. What a reader can see here is the shape the export will take and where its two halves meet.

D.1 Not everything called a gate record is decision-time

An institution looking for its gate records will find several kinds, and treating them as one kind is the error this appendix exists to prevent. Pipeline definitions, gate doctrine and improvement backlogs describe the gates an institution intends to operate. Only what the running system writes at the moment of a decision is decision-time evidence. The rest is intent, and 2.4 of [4] and 3.4 of [3] exclude it.

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An institution that answers a reconstruction request with its pipeline configuration has produced its intentions.

D.2 The trace is a join, and neither half is sufficient alone

Two runtime records are held.

One carries who did what, to which target, and when. It establishes that a named actor did a named thing at a named time.

The other carries the policy version in force, the propagated event identity, and the decision together with its basis. It establishes why the action was taken, and under which rules.

The trace is their join on the event identity. That is what this appendix exhibits: **the binding of a decision to the policy version in force at the time of that decision is a property of the join rather than of either record alone.** Read apart, the first is an access log and the second is an unattributed decision. Read together, they are the artifact 2.1 requires.

An institution holding both and unable to join them holds neither. That is 2.3 in one system rather than in the abstract.

D.3 What the redacted export will contain

Element	What the row will show
Event identity	The join key, redacted to a stable surrogate, identical on both sides so the join survives redaction
Actor, action, target	Actor replaced by a role surrogate; action and target as written
Time	As written
Policy version in force	As written. 2.5 of [4] and IP-4 of [2] identify this as the field a reconstruction most needs
Decision and its basis	As written, payloads excluded
The join	Each step of the account attributed to the record that evidences it, per 6.1 element 7

D.4 The gap the export will declare

One artifact class the export cannot supply will be named in the export itself. The trace will therefore report itself **partial** under 6.3: naming the missing artifact, naming the question it cannot answer, and naming the remedy and its owner.

This is the appendix obeying the specification rather than a defect in it. A worked trace reporting itself complete while a member of its evidence set was absent would breach 5.2.7 of [2] inside the document that requires obedience to it.

D.5 Why no illustrative substitute appears

Every other worked example in this corpus is declared an illustrative construction that cannot test the properties it exhibits [1][2]. This appendix is different in kind. Its whole value is that the records are real.

A fabricated trace would be indistinguishable to a reader from a genuine one. That is why none appears here. Until the export is published, 11.1 governs and the evidence level is E1.

Document History

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Version	Date	Summary
1.0	6 September 2026	First public version. Six stages; the reconstruction precondition stated as a citation of its four producers rather than as a restatement; the signal register including non-incidents; the reconstruction report and the partial-reporting rule outside the engineering family; the notifiability decision record; the derived conformance test; the incident taxonomy annex; the naming crosswalk to the seven-phase prior treatment; Appendix D specified as a two-table join with its export outstanding; evidence level stated as E1 until that export is published

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About the Author

Nabeel Khan is an enterprise AI architect and governance advisor, and Founder & Solutions Architect at iSystematic Inc. He has spent twenty-five years architecting enterprise data and machine-learning systems in government, healthcare, financial services and telecommunications across three continents, grounded in TOGAF, DMBOK, ISO 27001 and SOC 2.

He works on governed production AI; systems whose authority is bounded by the architecture, whose decisions carry the evidence needed to defend them, and whose behaviour the institution can explain afterwards. The frameworks specified here, and the regulatory knowledge behind them, are published as machine-accessible AI expertise and are callable over MCP without a key at mcp.nabeelkhan.com/api/mcp, so a reader may query this specification's contents directly and receive answers carrying their source.

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```

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